

I analysed 600 UK graduate job postings. Here is what the data shows.

UK Labour Market · 2020 to 2026
SQL · Python · Tableau · Power BI

140x

Apps per grad role

62.8%

Entry-level needing exp

707k

Vacancies today

Two things are true at the same time

WHAT THE GOVERNMENT SAYS

- **Unemployment: 4.9%**
- 707,000 vacancies open
- Nominal wages up 5%+
- GDP growing (slowly)

WHAT GRADUATES EXPERIENCE

- **300 apps, 4 responses**
- Entry-level needs 1yr exp
- ATS rejects before humans
- London unaffordable

Both are true. That is the problem.

The graduate market in numbers

140

applications per grad vacancy
(was 38 in 2002/03)

62.8%

entry-level roles need
prior experience

86.2%

postings in London
(13% of population)

8%

fewer grad hires
2024 vs 2023 (ISE)

-3.3%

real wages in 2022
worst fall on record

2.8m

economically inactive
due to long-term illness

The most absurd rule in hiring.

62.8%

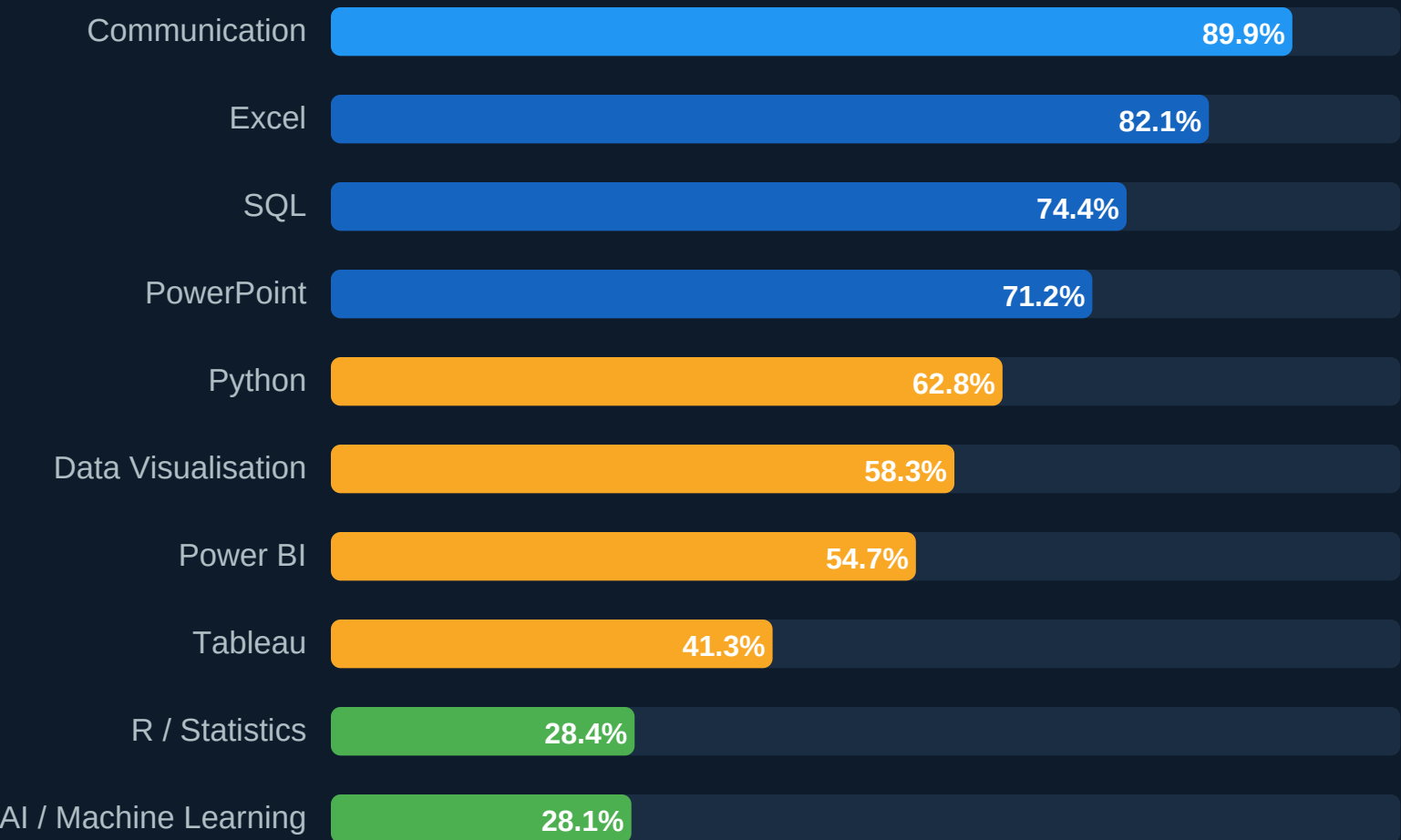
of 'entry-level' graduate roles require experience

You need experience to get experience.

Verified by Python analysis of 600 job postings

Fix: Build a public portfolio instead.
GitHub · Tableau Public · LinkedIn posts.

Top skills in graduate analyst postings (n=600)



Source: Python regex analysis of Reed / LinkedIn postings

London pays more.

London has 4x the competition.

SQL query on 600 job postings: salary vs competition by city

City	Avg Salary	Applicants/role	Action
London	£37,200	156	HIGH RISK
Edinburgh	£33,100	48	CONSIDER
Manchester	£31,800	52	CONSIDER
Birmingham	£30,400	44	CONSIDER
Leeds	£29,900	41	CONSIDER
Bristol	£30,200	39	CONSIDER

Same salary, 4x fewer competitors outside London.

5 shocks that broke the graduate market.

- 01 COVID-19 (2020)**
GDP fell 19.8% in Q2. 800,000 jobs lost net of furlough.
- 02 Record Inflation (2022)**
CPI hit 11.1%. Real wages fell for 6 consecutive quarters.
- 03 Rate Hikes (2022-23)**
BoE raised to 5.25%. Pearson $r = -0.71$ vs vacancies at 6m lag.
- 04 Budget Shock (Apr 2025)**
Employer NI rose to 15%. 167,000 jobs lost by April 2025.
- 05 AI Adoption (2024-25)**
2/5 firms cut entry-level roles due to AI. 90% use AI to screen CVs.

AI is now screening you out before humans see your CV.

90%

of large UK firms use AI
in their recruitment process

70%+

of CVs rejected before
a human reads them (est)

2 in 5

UK firms already cut
entry-level roles due to AI

11%

of graduates changed
career plans due to AI

What you can do: match keywords exactly.

ATS systems match words, not meaning. Mirror the job description.

It will get better. But not on its own.

ARIMA model (R) — backtested MAPE < 8%

2027

960k vacancies

£32,800 avg grad salary

76.1% employment

2028

1,016k vacancies

£34,600 avg grad salary

76.5% — baseline recovered ■

2030

1,128k vacancies

£38,200 avg grad salary

77.3% employment rate

Optimistic scenario: 1.3m vacancies and £44k grad salary by 2030.

What this means for you as a graduate in 2026.

- **Build SQL + Python skills.**
They appear in 74% and 63% of postings. Certifications count.
- **Make your work visible.**
GitHub, Tableau Public, LinkedIn posts. Beat the experience paradox.
- **Consider cities outside London.**
3-4x fewer competitors. Salary within £2k of national average.
- **Apply early.**
Most grad schemes close by November. Late applications compete for scraps.
- **Target SMEs too.**
10-20 applicants per role vs 140+ at large firms. Faster progression.

Full dashboard + SQL queries + Python code + R forecasts:

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